

Yijin Fang

Tsinghua University, Beijing, China

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Education

Department of Psychological and Cognitive Sciences, Tsinghua University

Beijing, China

PhD candidate in Psychology

2022 - 2027 (expected)

- Advisor: Dr. Stella Christie
- Research focus: cognitive development, explore-exploit decisions, curiosity and learning

Department of Psychology, University of California, Berkeley

Berkeley, CA, US

Visiting scholar in KiddLab

2025.08-2025.12

- Advisor: Dr. Celeste Kidd

Department of Psychological and Cognitive Sciences, Tsinghua University

Beijing, China

Enrolled in the MA program in Psychology

2019 - 2022

- Advisor: Dr. Stella Christie
- Completed masters requirements before transitioning to the PhD program
- Research focus: Children's learning from play

Fujian Medical University

Fujian, China

BS in Applied Psychology, specializing in clinical psychology

2014 - 2018

Publications

In Prep

Fang, Y., Yang, H.A., Zhang, Y., Christie, S. (in prep). Explore-exploit decisions between rural and urban children in middle childhood.

Fang, Y., Christie, S. (in prep). Knowing less, exploring more? How knowledge base affects explore-exploit decisions.

Fang, Y., Zheng, Y., Christie, S. (in prep). Scaffolding relational abstraction: Does broader comparison promote broader transfer?

Under Review

Masters, A.S., Robinson, J., Gibbs, H., Lyu, J., **Fang, Y.**, Christie, S., Golinkoff, R.M., Hirsh-Pasek, K. (under review). Parents' understanding of playful learning in the United States and China. *Frontiers in Education*.

Published

Fang, Y., Christie, S. (2026). Knowing less, exploring more? Metacognitive regulation of knowledge in explore-exploit decisions. In *Proceedings of the 48th Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*.

Fang, Y., Chang, A., Christie, S. (2026). Effects of encouraging vs. reflective feedback on children's explore-exploit decisions. In *Proceedings of the 48th Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*.

Fang, Y., Yang, H.A., Christie, S. (2025). Early experiences shape children's explore-exploit decisions: Evidence from the rural-urban gap. In *Proceedings of the 47th Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*.

Fang, Y., Yang, H., Christie, S. (2024). The Effect of Perceived vs. Factual Knowledge on Exploration. In *Proceedings of the 46th Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*.

Lyu, J., **Fang, Y.**, Fan, W., Yang, H., Christie, S. (2022). 早期玩要是终身学习的基础 [Early play serves as a foundation for lifelong learning]. [*Early Child Development*]. 1, 9-23.

Christie, S., Lyu, J., **Fang, Y.**, Han, X. (2020). The Cognitive Science of Designing Urban Spaces for Children. *Landscape Architecture Frontiers*. 2(8), 84-99.

Presentations & Posters

Conference Presentations

Fang, Y., Christie, S. (2025). The drive for knowledge in shaping explore-exploit decisions: The role of perception and self-monitoring. Oral presentation: Tsinghua Laboratory of Brain and Intelligence Seminar Series (THBI-SS) on Mar.14th, Beijing, China.

Fang, Y., Christie, S. (2023). Explore or exploit? The impact of knowledge on exploration behaviors. Oral presentation: Tsinghua Laboratory of Brain and Intelligence Seminar Series (THBI-SS) on Dec.7th, Beijing, China.

Lyu, J.*, **Fang, Y.***, Christie, S. (2021). Learning from play: The mechanisms and constraints. Oral presentation: the 14th International Conference on Brain Informatics, Padova, Italy.

Conference Posters

Fang, Y., Christie, S. (2026). Knowing less, exploring more? Metacognitive regulation of knowledge in explore-exploit decisions. Poster: the 48th Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society, Rio de Janeiro, Brazil.

Fang, Y., Chang, A., Christie, S. (2026). Effects of encouraging vs. reflective feedback on children's explore-exploit decisions. Poster: the 48th Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society, Rio de Janeiro, Brazil.

Fang, Y., Yang, H.A., Christie, S. (2025). Early experiences in shaping children's explore-exploit decisions: evidence from the rural-urban gap. Poster: the 47th Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society, San Francisco, USA.

Fang, Y., Yang, H., Christie, S. (2024). The Effect of Perceived vs. Factual Knowledge on Exploration. Poster: the 46th Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society, Rotterdam, the Netherlands.

Awards, Fellowships, & Grants

2025	Graduate Student short-term visiting scholarship, Tsinghua University	\$ 6500
2024	Graduate Division Conference Travel Grant, Tsinghua University	\$ 1500
2023	“Future Social Designer” Research Grant, Tsinghua University	\$ 800

Additional Research Experience _____

Cross-cultural differences in parental attitude towards play and learning *Beijing, China*
led by Dr. Hirsh-Pasek Kathy’s team *Sep 2020 –Aug 2022*

- Research focus: Differences in parental attitudes toward children’s play and learning. Cultural influences on these parental attitudes.

Children’s learning from free play *Beijing, China*
Collaborator: Jinyun Lyu, advised by Dr. Stella Christie *Sep 2019 –Aug 2022*

- Research focus: Learning mechanisms of free play. Cultural influences on children’s learning through play.

Teaching Experience _____

Spring 2024,
Fall 2022, Introduction to Psychology, Teaching Assistant
Fall 2021
Spring 2022 Introduction to Cognitive Science, Teaching Assistant

Community Service _____

Theoretical and Computational Neuroscience Summer School *Beijing, China*
Volunteers leader *Summer 2024*

Public Welfare Project – Caring for Migrant Children *Beijing, China*
Volunteer *Fall 2023*

Social Practice Project – Caring for Left-behind Children *Hubei, China*
Volunteer & organizer *Summer 2023*